It became an extremely vicious civil war, with thousands of men and women fighting and dying for a cause that most people in the rest of the world would consider a total anachronism. Maoist-inspired uprisings in the Third World were not uncommon in the 1960s and 1970s—but in the late 1990s and the beginning of the twenty-first century? Even the turgid prose used by the Nepalese Maoists seemed to belong to a different era. But ultra-leftism and Maoism did have firm roots in Nepalese politics. The country's first communist party, called simply the Communist Party of Nepal (CPN), was formed when four young Nepalese intellectuals met in Kolkata on 22 April 1949. One of them, Pushpa Lal Shrestha, or Comrade PL, as he was known, became the party's first general secretary and is considered the father of Nepalese communism.

Nepal experienced a brief period of relative democracy during the first years of the reign of King Tribhuvan, who had ascended the throne as an eight-year-old boy in 1911. The Nepalese kings were at that time in any case powerless figureheads, as the country had been run by hereditary prime ministers from the Rana family, old allies of the British, since 1846. In later years, the king, with support from independent India, began to challenge the Ranas. A popular movement to end the oligarchy also broke out in 1950, and, in early 1951, a compromise was reached during a meeting in New Delhi between King Tribhuvan, who had been living in exile in India for a year and supported the movement, the Ranas, and representatives of the main opposition party, the Nepali Congress. The king would form a new government under his leadership, consisting of the Nepali Congress and the Ranas on an equal basis. The king returned to Kathmandu on 18 February, and, on the 21st, he declared an end to the rule of the Rana autocracy. Nepal had begun its first experiment with democracy.

The CPN, which had played an important role in the overthrow of the Ranas, became a legal political party. But when the Nepali Congress party's militia, called Raksha Dal, rose in revolt in 1952, and the uprising was crushed, the CPN, which had been sympathetic to the uprising, was also banned. It was only when the ban was lifted four years later that the CPN could openly hold its congress in Kathmandu, and adopted a revolutionary party programme that advocated an end to monarchy and the establishment of a republic. The period of political openness was brief: On 15 December 1960, the new king, Mahendra, staged a coup. He suspended